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N.Y. Haitians demonstrate, on Feb. 14, 1974, in support of Haitian refugees jailed by U.S. Government in Miami. Fr. Rolland Pierre leads demonstration on Fifth Avenue. (Photo by T.J. Marino)

Up from Haiti: Another diaspora

Special to **Migration Today**

Half a million Haitians, ten percent of the five million inhabitants of the Caribbean Island of Haiti, are exiles and emigrants today. This latest diaspora from the poorest of the underdeveloped countries of the New World feeds the labor markets of North America and Europe. A familiar pattern is repeated. Haitians, Black, Creole - and French-speaking, mostly Catholic and mostly inexperienced with the post-industrial world of the 1970's, struggle to emerge from a history of violent outbursts, harsh social conditions and political repression and to preserve their fierce sense of independence.

Haiti Today

Published statistics on Haiti are limited. This Republic covers 27,700 square kilometers. The official figures on Haitian population reach about five million people. **80 per cent live in rural areas, plagued by all the familiar characteristics of poor education, poor housing and poor health.** The per capita income of Haiti is $70.00 per year, however only $30.00 in the rural areas. Over 80 per cent of the population is illiterate. An estimated 50 per cent of the 200 to 300 thousand work force living in urban areas are employed. From 1950 to 1971 a visible change takes place, more marked in recent years, in the rate of growth of the population. The urban population's growth was 132 per cent compared to only 26 per cent for the rural population. Apparently, then, the population movement to the capital city of Port-au-Prince and to Cap-Haitien is parallel to the increased emigration to New York, Miami, Montreal, Chicago, Nassau and Santo Domingo. Other problems, however, trouble the Haitians and force them to seek a livelihood elsewhere. **The political climate, under a more polished and public relations conscious surface than at the time of President Francois (Papa Doc) Duvalier, is still unhealthy for advocates of social reforms and free speech.**

In March of last year, Amnesty International, a recognized international source on political prisoners, followed up on statements issued by The Human Rights Commission of the Organization of American States, and wrote to President Duvalier stating: "Many hundreds of Haitians continue to suffer as political prisoners, to say nothing of those who have fled their homeland to escape persecution."

The economy, much of it in the hands of foreign entrepreneurs who grossly exploit the Haitian people, offers great imbalances and not enough jobs and opportunities for

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The pastoral care of migrants

The participants of the First European Meeting on the pastoral care of more than 12 million migrants affecting Europe held in the Vatican last October agreed, among other things, on the following points:

-The migrants are not merely valuable and irreplaceable cooperators in the economy of the country to which they give their services and, in a more general way, in European well-being; they are, above all, co-builders of the new world. However, their contribution to the birth of the new world is marked by hardship and suffering. Frequently their human and social condition fails to correspond to the requirements of justice. One deplores the failure to recognize basic human rights, the compulsory division of families due to restrictive measures or to scarcity of available housing, difficulties in the way of education and school attendance for the migrants' children, the tendency to exploit men as mere instruments of production, nationalist and racist prejudices which raise serious psychological barriers and sometimes lead to open rejection.

Emigration is a permanent invitation to the local Churches to open up and rediscover the meaning of the earthly pilgrimage. Bishops, priests, religious and laity must

(1) **question themselves** as regards their living witness and ask themselves if their acts are in harmony with what they publicly announce, especially in their contact with one another, in situations in which there is

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A national conference:

Seek action against immigration policies

The National Coalition for Fair Immigration Laws and Practices plans a national conference to be held in Los Angeles, Cal., on March 8-9 and 10th, 1974, at the Roosevelt High School (E. 3rd and Mott Sts.). Over 1,000 participants are expected to attend the conference.

Mark Day, Conference chairman, qualified the conference as "a call for action against Nixon's racist immigration policies and practices," specifically against the bills HR 981 and HR 982 which have passed the House of Representatives and on which action from the U.S. Senate is imminent, as well as against the dragnet deportation raids and other discriminatory immigration practices. "If HR 981 passes," reminded Mark Day, "the parents of children born in the U.S. will no longer be able to receive immigrant visas because of their familial relationship and will be summarily deported -- with their citizen children in their arms. If HR 981 passes, only 20,000 Mexicans will be able to lawfully immigrate each year ... and would keep family members separated ... HR 982 would require all social workers to report 'illegal aliens' to the immigration authorities, would prevent aliens from ever legalizing their status if they ever worked without permission in the U.S., and most drastically, would cause hundreds of thousands of persons to be fired from their jobs because of the color of their skins ..."

The conference will feature practical workshops such as the following:

(1) **"How to Defend Persons Detained by Immigration."**

(2) **"How to Obtain Job Security on All Levels for Workers Without Visas."**

(3) **"Social Security, Disability Insurance and Unemployment Insurance for Workers Without Visas."**

(4) **"How to Organize, Operate and Maintain a Defense Center For Families Without Visas."**

(5) **"Protecting the Rights of U.S. Born Children From Deportation."**

(6) **"Unionization and Obtaining the Fullest Equality in Rights and Service For Workers Without Visas and Their Families in the United States."**

(7) **"Building Coalitions With Other Groups and Organization in Our Fight."**

(8) **"Class Action Suits Now Being Carried Forward to Force the U.S. Immigration & Naturalization Service to Observe the Constitution in its Practices Towards Mexican and Other Latin American Persons Living in the U.S."**

These young Chinese are preparing picket signs for a demonstration against employers who exploit aliens. (Photo by Mark Day)

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